

Free kick routines

Free kicks come in many forms — direct strikes at goal, crosses into the box from wide areas, quick restarts and rehearsed indirect routines. This guide explains the main attacking and defending principles for each.

Set piece routines [Read about free kicks](#)

What free kick routines are

A free kick routine is a planned, rehearsed pattern of play used at a free kick.

Free kicks are awarded after a foul or a similar infringement. The attacking team gets the ball stopped, with at least 9.15 metres (10 yards) of space around it, and a few moments to decide what to do with it. That brief pause — much like at corners — gives the team time to set up rehearsed patterns rather than rely on what it would do in open play.

Free kicks are split into direct and indirect free kicks. A goal can be scored directly from a direct free kick. From an indirect free kick, the ball must be touched by another player before a goal can count. Indirect free kicks are awarded for specific technical offences, such as offside, dangerous play without contact or certain goalkeeper offences.

[Read about the rules of free kicks](#)

Free kicks within shooting range

A direct free kick within roughly 25-30 metres of goal is a clear shooting opportunity.

Over the wall

The most common direct free kick — a struck shot lifted over the defensive wall and dipping back down into the net. Requires accuracy and the right amount of dip; too much and the ball goes over the bar.

Around the wall

A bent shot that curves around the side of the wall rather than over it. Suits players who can hit the ball with significant curve, especially from positions wide of central.

Driven low

A hard, low shot under the wall as the wall jumps. Some defending teams place a player behind the wall, lying on the ground, to block this kind of shot if the wall jumps.

Knuckleball

A struck shot with very little spin, which dips and moves unpredictably in the air. Difficult to execute and difficult to defend, used mostly by specialist takers.

Free kicks from wider positions

Free kicks too wide or too far for a direct shot are usually crosses into the box.

From a wide position outside shooting range, the kicker delivers a cross into the penalty area. The patterns are similar to corners — specific runs by attackers, blockers screening defenders, and a player picking up the second ball at the edge of the area. The main difference is that the angle is different, which changes the kind of cross that works best.

Some teams use the wide free kick as a near-corner. They put their best aerial attackers in the box, deliver the cross to a specific zone, and treat the kick as a chance to attack from a known set position. Others use the free kick to play short, restarting the move in possession rather than crossing immediately.

Indirect free kick routines

Indirect free kicks have their own specific patterns.

Some of the most unusual indirect free kicks happen inside the penalty area. The defending team usually puts every available player on or near the goal line. The attacking team has to touch the ball to one player and then strike it into the net before the defenders can close the space, often with very little angle to work with.

Outside the box, indirect free kicks are less unusual but still distinct. A common routine is to play the ball short to a teammate, who then strikes a shot or delivers a cross after the required touch has been made.

Quick free kicks

Not every free kick is used as a set routine.

Sometimes the best free kick is taken quickly, before the opposition can organise its wall, marking or defensive shape. Quick free kicks are especially useful when the defending team has switched off after committing the foul.

A quick free kick is still a tactical choice. The taker has to judge whether the chance to attack an unorganised defence is better than waiting for teammates to set up a rehearsed delivery.

Defending free kicks

Defending a direct free kick close to goal involves three tasks at once.

[Read about zonal marking](#)

Setting the wall

A line of defenders forms a wall to block the direct shot. The wall stands at least 9.15 metres from the ball. The number of players in the wall depends on how good a shooting position the ball is in — more players for shots from central, fewer for shots from wide angles.

The goalkeeper's positioning

The goalkeeper covers the side of the goal not protected by the wall. They stand near the edge of that side of the goal, ready to dive across to the wall side if the shot is bent around or over it.

Marking in the box

Defenders mark the opposition's attackers in the box, in case the kick becomes a cross. Most teams use a similar marking system to corners — a mix of zonal and man-to-man marking, depending on the team's defensive style.

Counter-attack threat

One or two attackers usually stay high up the pitch when defending a free kick deep in their own half. A clearance played to them can become a quick counter-attack against an opposition with players forward.

The wall and how to attack it

The wall is the main defensive feature of any free kick within shooting range.

A standard wall is three to five players, depending on the angle of the kick. The wall stands shoulder-to-shoulder with their hands by their sides, jumps as the ball is struck, and tries to block the shot. Most goalkeepers prefer a four- or five-player wall from central positions and a smaller wall from wider angles.

Attacking teams have several ways to beat the wall. They can use decoy runners, lay-offs or players positioned legally near the wall to disturb the goalkeeper's view or change the shooting angle. Some routines use two players running over the ball as decoys before a third player takes the actual kick.

Specialist takers

Most teams have one or two players who take all the team's free kicks within shooting range.

The skills required for free kick taking are specific. The kicker needs to strike the ball cleanly, with the right amount of curve or dip, from a standing position with no run-up to speak of. Most players are not particularly good at this. The few who are quickly become their team's permanent free kick taker, and other team-mates rarely take the chance.

Goalkeepers research opposition specialists. They study the kicker's preferred technique, where they aim, and how often they bend the ball around the wall versus over it. Some specialists are predictable enough that the goalkeeper knows where the shot is going before it is taken; others are so accurate that being able to anticipate where the ball will go does not help much.